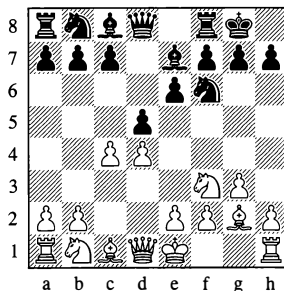


Chapter 15

Catalan 4...♘e7



Closed System

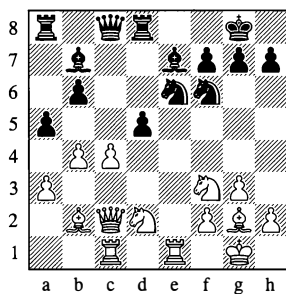
Variation Index

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♙e7 5.♙g2 0-0

6.0-0

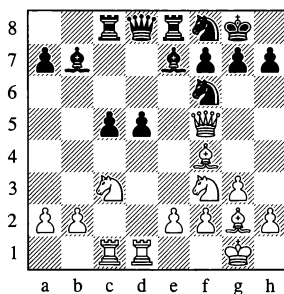
A) 6...c6	229
B) 6...♘bd7 7.♙c2	232
B1) 7...b6 8.cxd5	232
B11) 8...♘xd5	233
B12) 8...exd5	234
B2) 7...c6 8.♘bd2 b6 9.e4	235
B21) 9...dxe4	236
B22) 9...♙b7 10.e5 ♘e8 11.cxd5	237
B221) 11...exd5	237
B222) 11...cxd5 12.♙e1	239
B2221) 12...♙a6	240
B2222) 12...♙c7	241
B2223) 12...♙c8	243
B23) 9...♙a6 10.b3 ♙c8 11.♙b2 c5 12.exd5 exd5 13.♙fd1!	245
B231) 13...♙e8	248
B232) 13...cxd4	249

A) note to 14...♙c8



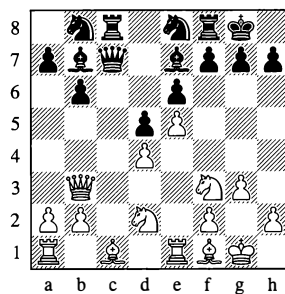
17.♘g5!N

B12) after 14...bxc5



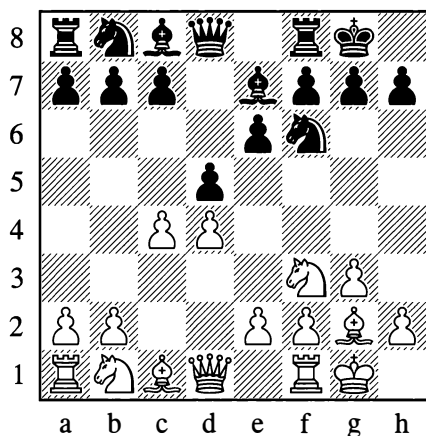
15.♘g5!N

B2222) after 14...♘b8



15.♘b1!N

1.d4 ♘f6 2.c4 e6 3.g3 d5 4.♘f3 ♙e7 5.♙g2
0-0 6.0-0



From this position Black's most popular continuation has been 6...dxc4, which will be discussed in the next chapter. The present chapter will focus on the Closed Catalan positions that may arise after A) 6...c6 or B) 6...♘bd7.

A) 6...c6

This usually leads to the main lines after a subsequent ...♘bd7, but there are some independent possibilities. Recently Black came up with an interesting idea of developing the knight to a6.

7.♙c2 b6 8.♘bd2 ♙b7

8...♙a6

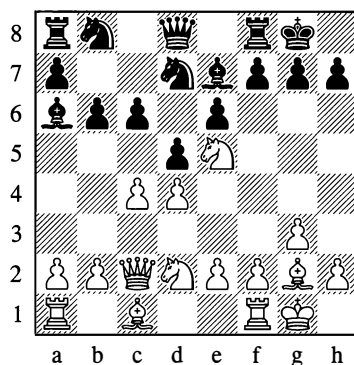
This prevents e2-e4 for the moment, as the c4-pawn would be hanging after a double capture on e4, but White has another strong move at his disposal.

9.♘e5

A typical move in the Closed Catalan.

9...♘fd7

Nobody has tried 9...dxc4?! yet, and rightly so, as after 10.♘dxc4 the d4-pawn is untouchable: 10...♙xd4? 11.♞d1 ♙c5 12.♙e3 ♙b5 13.a4 ♙b4 14.♙d2 ♙c5 15.b4 ♙d4 16.♙e3+ – Black's queen is trapped.



10.♘d3!

White has a space advantage, so it makes sense to avoid the knight swap.

10...♘f6

10...♙f6 11.e3 ♙b7 12.b4 gave White a pleasant edge in Ovetchkin – Mokshanov, Tyumen 2012.

11.♞d1!

Only this accurate move – which I recommended in *GM 1* and has since been tested in one game – promises White an advantage.

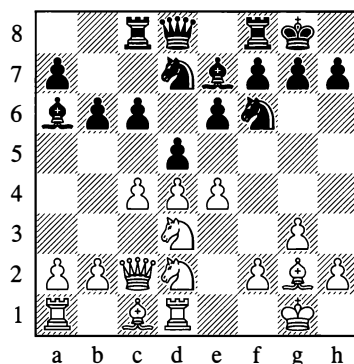
11.e3 soon led to a clear advantage for White in Gheorghiu – Radulov, Budapest 1970, but only because Black failed to play 11...c5!N, which would have given him a reasonable position.

11...♘bd7

11...dxc4 12.♘xc4 ♙xd4? 13.♘de5 transposes to 9...dxc4?! 10.♘dxc4 ♙xd4?

11.♞d1 as mentioned above.

12.e4 ♞c8



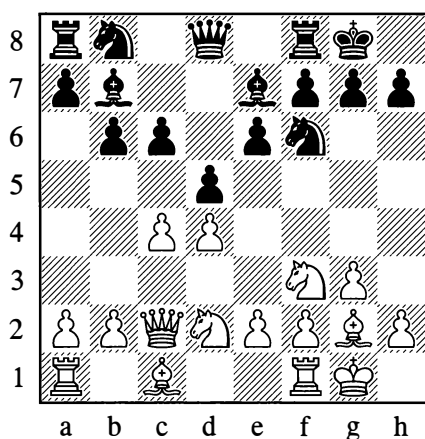
This position occurred in Brunello – Tristan, Porto Madryn 2009. Instead of pushing the pawn to e5, I would prefer to maintain the tension for a moment longer with:

13.b3!N

Black's position is not easy, as the obvious freeing move runs into a problem:

13...c5 14.exd5 exd5 15.dxc5 ♖xc5 16.♗xc5 ♙xc5 17.♗e4!

Black will soon lose the d-pawn.



9.e4 ♗a6!?

This move has been known since the late 1980s, and it has become fairly popular recently, mostly thanks to the efforts of GM Kovalyov, as well as the young Indian talent Vidit.

9...dxe4 10.♗xe4 ♗bd7 and 9...♗bd7 transpose to the later variations B21 and B22 respectively.

10.a3

This modest move is White's best chance for an advantage.

Black's main idea is revealed after 10.e5 ♗d7 11.cxd5 ♗b4!, when a subsequent ...♗xd5 and ...c5 will give Black an easy game.

10...c5

This is the main move, but Black has also tried:

10...♙c8 11.e5 ♗d7 12.cxd5

12.b4 c5 13.dxc5 bxc5 14.b5 ♗c7 15.a4 is interesting but rather double-edged.

12...cxd5 13.♙d1

This looks like the most convenient square for the queen.

13...♗ab8 14.♙e1 ♙c7 15.♗b1!

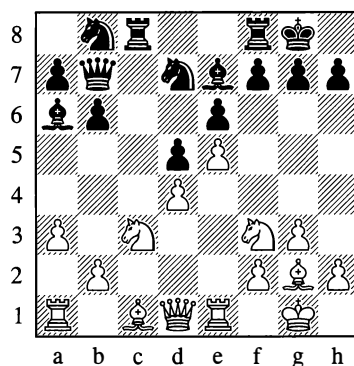
This is White's key idea, anticipating ...♙c2 and preparing to post the knight on c3, where it seriously hampers Black's play on the queenside, leaving White with excellent prospects on the kingside.

15...♙a6

15...♙c2N 16.♙xc2 ♙xc2 17.♗c3 f6 Black does not have much choice, as White was threatening to trap the rook with either ♙f1-d3 or ♙d1 followed by ♗e1. However, White has another unpleasant idea: 18.exf6 ♙xf6 19.♙f4! ♙xb2 (19...♗c6 20.♙eb1! leaves Black helpless against the plan of ♙e3 and ♗e1.) 20.♗g5! ♗f8 21.♗d1! White wins material.

16.♗c3 ♙b7

Now in Plischki – Stross, Prague 2014, the right way to seize the initiative was:

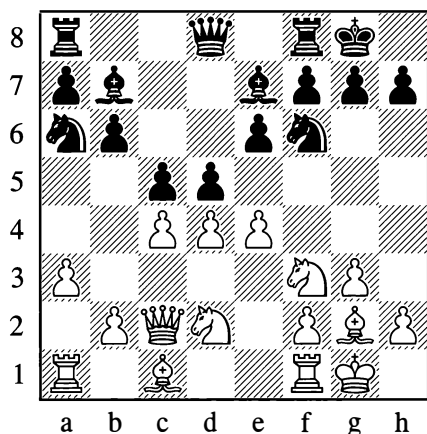


17.♗g5!N ♙fe8

17...h6 18.♗xe6! fxe6 19.♙g4 looks extremely dangerous.

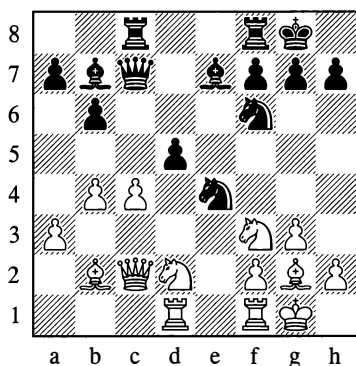
18.♙h5 ♙xg5 19.♙xg5 ♗c6 20.♙g4

White has good attacking chances.



11.exd5 exd5 12.dxc5 dxc5 13.b4 dxe6

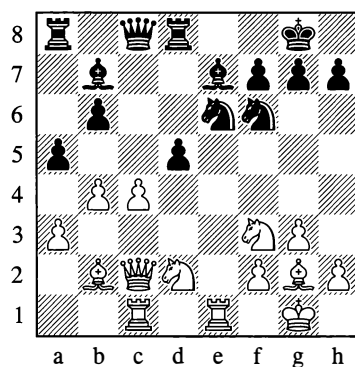
This move has been played in all the games where this position arose. I also considered the natural-looking alternative: 13...dce4N 14.♙b2 ♖c8 (14...dxd2 is more solid, but after 15.dxd2 ♗c7 16.♗fe1 dxc4 17.♙xb7 ♗xb7 18.dxc4± the difference between the dark-squared bishops is significant, despite the symmetrical pawn structure.) 15.♞ad1 ♗c7



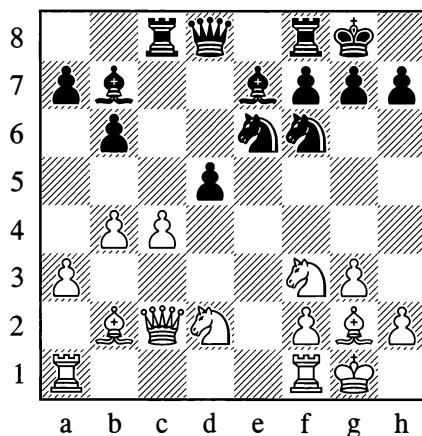
16.d4! dxd2 17.♗xd2 dxc4 (After 17...♗xc4 18.♞c1 ♗a6 19.d5 White's attack is decisive.) 18.d5! Surprisingly enough, White's attack is crushing, for example: 18...h6 19.♗fe1 ♗fe8 20.♞xe7 ♞xe7 21.♙xf6+–

14.♙b2 ♖c8

14...♗c8 15.♞ac1 ♞d8 16.♗fe1 a5 occurred in Wojtkiewicz – Velz, Neuchatel 1996. Here I found a nice improvement:



17.♙g5! N d4 (Worse is 17...dxc5?! 18.♞xe7 ♞d7 19.♙xf6 gxf6 20.♞xd7 ♗xd7 21.h4! d3+ 22.dfl and Black will lose his knight.) 18.♙xb7 ♗xb7 19.dxe6 fxe6 20.♗b3± Black will have a hard time defending the d4-pawn.



15.d5 ♗c7 16.♞ac1 ♗fd8

I also checked 16...dxc4N 17.♗xc4 ♗d8 (17...♗b8 runs into the unpleasant 18.♙c6!) and now the queen sacrifice 18.♙xb7!? ♞xc4 19.dxc4 is surprisingly promising for White, whose main idea is to install a knight on c6.

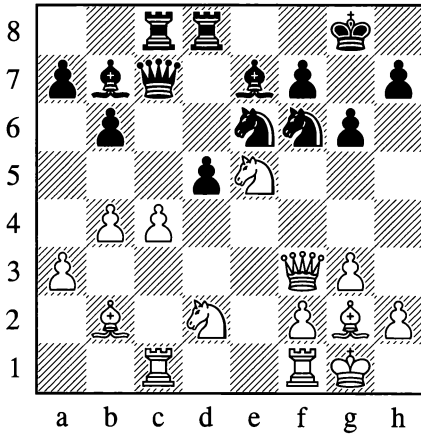
16...d4N may be Black's best try, although 17.♙xb7 ♗xb7 18.♞cd1 maintains an edge for White.

17.♗f5! g6 18.♗f3N

18.♗h3 d4 occurred in Hergott – Hoffman, Matanzas 1993, and now White should have

played: 19.♙xb7 ♖xb7 20.♗fe1 Threatening ♖xf7. 20...♗d6 21.f4 With a nice initiative.

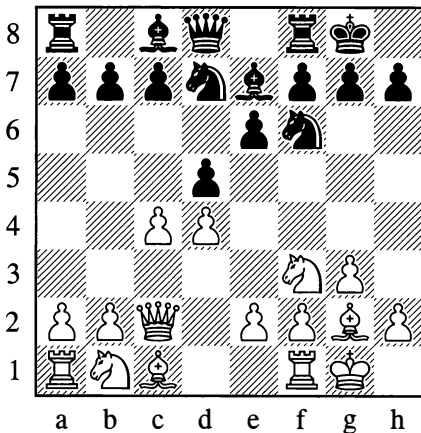
The text move seems like a simpler way to maintain the pressure. A possible continuation is:



18...dxc4 19.♖xb7 ♖xd2 20.♗xc4 ♖xb7 21.♙xb7 ♗xc4 22.♖xc4 ♗c2 23.♗c1 ♗xc1† 24.♙xc1±

The endgame will be torture for Black, as the light-squared bishop is too strong.

B) 6...♖bd7 7.♖c2

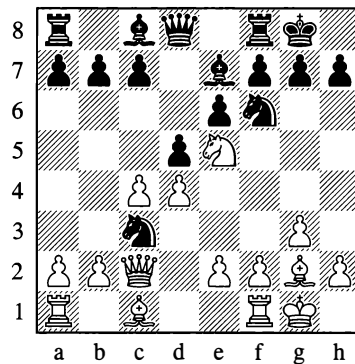


At this point we should consider the Queen's-Indian-like **B1) 7...b6**, although **B2) 7...c6** is,

of course, the most popular continuation by far. The following alternatives can be dealt with quickly:

7...c5 8.cxd5 ♖xd5 (8...exd5 9.♖c3± will either result in a Tarrasch Defence where Black's knight is misplaced on d7, or a transposition to variation B12 below after 9...b6 etc.) 9.♖c3 White stands better and has achieved a huge score from this position. One example continued 9...♖b4 10.♖b3 cxd4 11.♖xd4 ♖b6? 12.♙e3 ♖c5 13.♖c4!+ and Black was already losing material in Espig – Moehring, Potsdam 1974.

7...♖e4 does not make much sense, as after 8.♖c3 Black does not have time to set up a Stonewall formation. 8...♖df6 (After 8...♖xc3 9.♖xc3 ♙f6 10.♗d1 c6 11.♙f4 White obtained a pleasant edge thanks to his space advantage in Miroshnichenko – Boons, Leuven 2006.) 9.♖e5 ♖xc3



10.bxc3! This structural change is highly beneficial for White. 10...c5 11.♗d1 dxc4 12.♖xc4 cxd4 13.cxd4 White had a stable positional advantage in Hillarp Persson – Archer, Guernsey 2012.

B1) 7...b6 8.cxd5

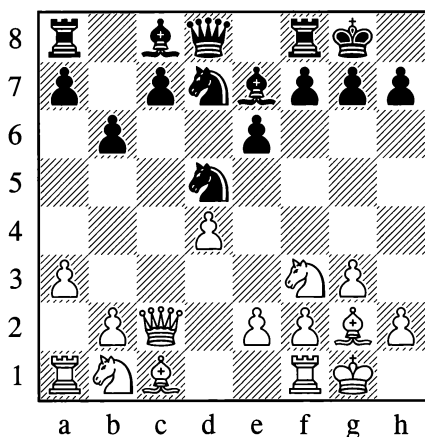
I think this is more precise than 8.♖c3 ♙b7 9.cxd5 ♖xd5! 10.♖xd5 exd5 11.♙f4 c5, when

the knight exchange had improved Black's chances in Plenkovic – Rogic, Zupanja 2008.

We will check both recaptures: **B11) 8...♖xd5** and **B12) 8...exd5**.

B11) 8...♖xd5 9.a3

White should cover the b4-square, as 9.e4 ♖b4 10.♖b3 c5 leads to double-edged play.



9...♖b7 10.e4 ♖5f6 11.♖c3 c5

Without this White would have a comfortable advantage.

12.♞d1

12.d5 exd5 13.exd5 looks tempting, but the critical 13...♖xd5!N has not yet been played. After 14.♖xd5 ♖xd5 15.♞d1 ♖e6 16.♖f4 ♖f6 the position seems pretty double-edged. White can try 17.♖d2 (17.♞d2 also deserves consideration), but after 17...♖d4! it is Black who will get reasonable compensation for the exchange.

12...cxd4 13.♖xd4

Black faces some problems with the coordination of his pieces.

13...♞c8

This has been the usual choice.

13...♞c8 14.♞e2 ♖c5 occurred in Quinteros – Medina Garcia, Olot 1971, when for some reason White refrained from the strong and obvious 15.e5±.

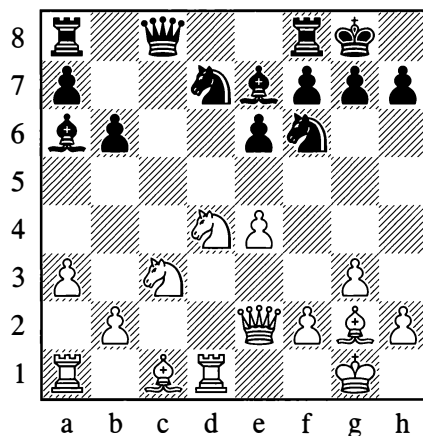
13...♞c7 14.♞e2! once again sets up the unpleasant threat of e4-e5. Black tried 14...♖c5 in Barcza – Liebert, Debrecen 1969, and here 15.♖cb5!N ♖b8 16.♖f4 e5 17.♖f5 ♖d8 18.♖g5± would have emphasized White's advantage.

14.♞e2!

Another novelty from *GM 1* which has since been tested in practice.

14...♖a6

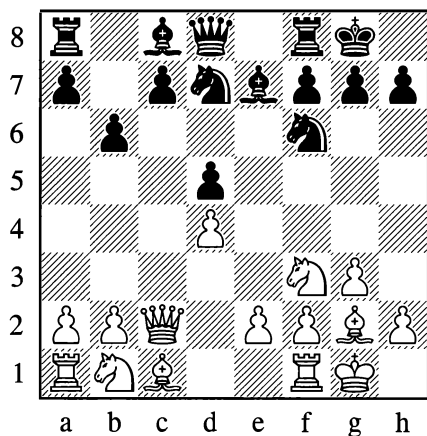
Other moves are possible, but it is not hard for White to maintain some advantage. After the text move I would like to show a simple improvement over Trella – Konijn, Netherlands 2014.



15.♖cb5N ♖c5 16.a4 ♖e5 17.♖b3

White is clearly better; he controls more space and Black's pieces are highly unstable.

B12) 8...exd5



9.♘c3

9.♙c6 ♜b8 10.♙f4 seems tempting, but after 10...♙b7 11.♙xc7 ♙xc7 12.♙xc7 ♜bc8 13.♙f4 ♜c2 Black had reasonable counterplay in Zelcic – Dusi, Madonna di Campiglio 1991.

9...♙b7 10.♙f4

We now have a typical Queen's Indian position, with a pawn structure that slightly favours White – especially as Black has lost the option of developing his knight via a6. I don't see much point in analysing this position in detail, as it is only a rare occurrence via the Catalan move order, so I will just focus on a few key lines.

10...c5

10...c6 is rather passive, and after 11.♜fd1 ♜e8 12.♘e5 ♘f8 13.e4 ♘e6 14.♙e3± White had a pleasant edge in Kunte – Lalith, Mumbai 2008, and a few other games.

11.♜fd1 ♜c8 12.♙f5!?

This is actually quite a common motif in this type of structure.

12.dxc5 ♘xc5 13.♙h3 ♘e6 14.♙e5 ♘d7 15.♙d4 ♜c4 was decent enough for Black in

the recent game Goganov – T.L. Petrosian, Yerevan 2014.

12...♜e8

12...g6?! looks too weakening after 13.♙h3.

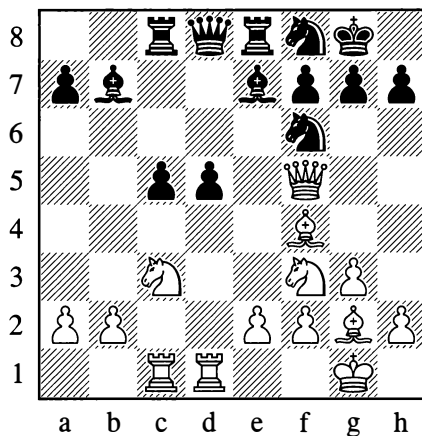
13.♜ac1 ♘f8 14.dxc5!

Good timing.

14...bxc5

Both 14...♙xc5 15.♙g5 and 14...♜xc5 15.♘d4 give White a favourable version of the IQP structure.

Here I found a significant improvement over Goksel – Yildiz, Antalya 2004.



15.♘g5!N

I also considered 15.♘e5!?N, but found it less convincing after 15...g6! (15...♙d6?! 16.♘g4! removes a key defender and wins the d5-pawn) 16.♙d3 ♙d6 17.♘xd5 ♙xd5 18.♙xd5 ♙xe5 when White does not seem to have a route to an advantage.

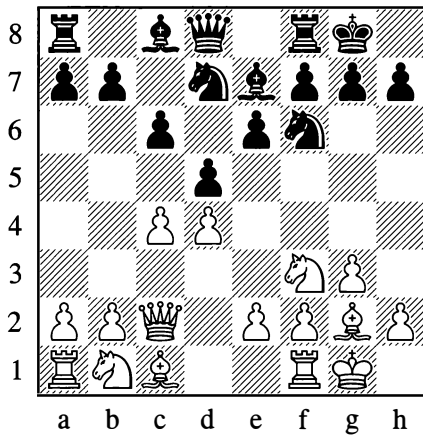
15...g6 16.♙c2

White maintains pressure against the d5-pawn. A logical continuation is:

16...♘e6 17.♘xd5! ♘xd5 18.♘xe6 fxe6 19.e4±

Black remains under pressure.

B2) 7...c6



We have already covered the similar position where the white bishop has been lured to d2. Here White can prepare e2-e4 much more conveniently.

8. ♖bd2 b6

This is the main line by far. Many moves have been tried, but in most cases White will simply play e2-e4 and get an advantage in a similar fashion to the lines examined below. Therefore I will only mention one alternative, which leads to a different type of game.

8...b5?!

This is premature in view of White's strong reply.

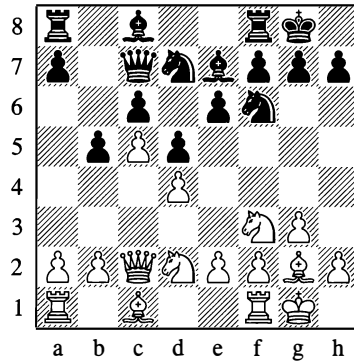
9.c5!

Black should only allow this type of position if he able to prevent e2-e4, which is obviously not the case here.

9...♞c7

9...a5 10.e4 dxe4 11.♜xe4 ♜xe4 12.♞xe4 leads to a thematic situation where Black's light-squared bishop is too passive and White has good chances to seize the initiative on the kingside. One model game continued 12...♜f6 13.♞c2 (13.♞xc6?! ♔d7 14.♞b6 ♞xb6 15.cxb6 ♞ab8 gives Black a reasonable endgame) 13...♜d5 14.♞e1 ♜f6 15.h4 a4 16.a3 ♞c7 17.♜g5 and White was

clearly better in Khismatullin – Stanojoski, Plovdiv 2008.



10.e4 e5

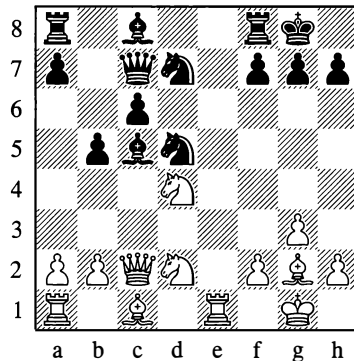
This avoids the fate of the previous note, but Black is not ready to create this level of tension in the centre.

11.exd5 ♜xd5

11...cxd5 12.dxe5 ♜xe5 13.♜b3 ♜xf3† 14.♜xf3 ♜e4 occurred in Ibragimov – Marcelin, Linares 2001, and now 15.♞d1N ♜b7 16.♜f4± would have given White a clear positional advantage.

12.♞e1! exd4 13.♜xd4 ♜xc5

No better is 13...♜xc5 14.♜b3 ♜xb3 15.axb3 ♜b4 16.♞c3 and White will recover the pawn with interest.



14.♜b3 ♞b6 15.♜xc5 ♜xc5 16.♜xc6

This small combination works fine, although 16.♜d2!N followed by ♞ac1 might be even stronger.

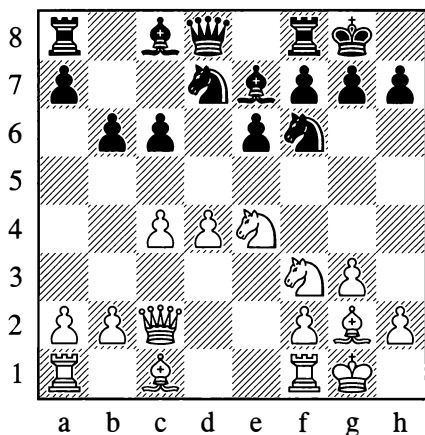
16...♜xc6 17.♙e3 ♙e6 18.♜xc5 ♜xc5 19.♙xc5

With two bishops in an open position, White had strong positional pressure in Petursson – Sorensen, Copenhagen 1981.

9.e4

This move brings us to the main branching point of the chapter. **B21) 9...dxe4** has been played in a lot of games, but I consider it a clear concession from Black. Our main focus will be on the more challenging options of **B22) 9...♙b7** and **B23) 9...♙a6**.

B21) 9...dxe4 10.♘xe4



Black's main problem is that he usually fails to free his position with ...c5 in a favourable situation, and thus may end up in a passive position with an inferior light-squared bishop.

10...♘xe4

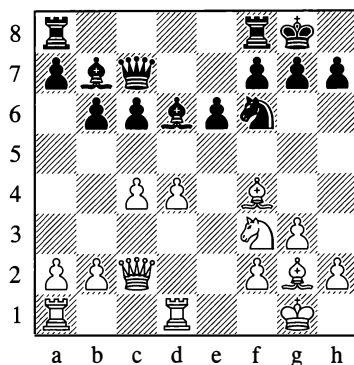
10...♙b7 11.♞d1 is likely to transpose to one of the lines below after a subsequent knight exchange.

11.♜xe4 ♙b7 12.♞d1 ♜c8

This is the only critical line, as Black is trying his hardest to prepare ...c5.

If Black plays passively then he may soon find himself in a positional bind. A good

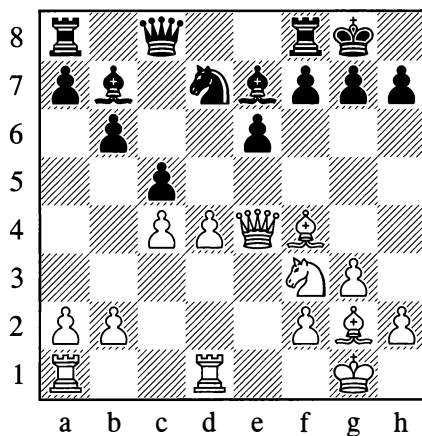
illustration is: 12...♘f6 13.♜c2 (13.♜e2 is also promising) 13...♜c7 14.♙f4 ♙d6



15.♙xd6 ♜xd6 16.c5! ♜c7 17.♘e5± White has succeeded in shutting Black's light-squared bishop out of the game, and he has the strong positional plan of ♘e5-c4-d6. The database contains a long list of games from this position, consisting of many white wins and a few draws here and there.

13.♙f4 c5

Sometimes Black starts with 13...♞e8, but after 14.♜c2 c5 15.d5 it transposes.



14.d5 ♞e8

14...♙f6 15.♜c2 exd5 16.cxd5 leaves Black with nothing better than 16...♞e8, transposing to the main line.

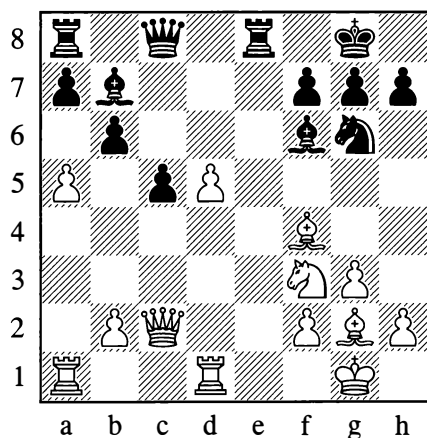
15. ♖c2 exd5 16. cxd5 ♕f6

We have reached a critical moment. After investigating this position for the second time, I concluded that a slight change of direction was needed.

17. a4!

In *GM 1* I gave this as an interesting alternative, but now I believe it should take centre stage.

My previous recommendation of 17. ♖g5 does not look so convincing now in view of: 17... ♗xg5 (17... ♖f8?! runs into 18. ♖e4! followed by ♖d6) 18. ♗xg5 ♖e5! (I overlooked this in *GM 1* and only mentioned a game with 18... ♖f8) 19. h3 ♗d7 Black was fine in Maurer – Dreis, corr. 2001.

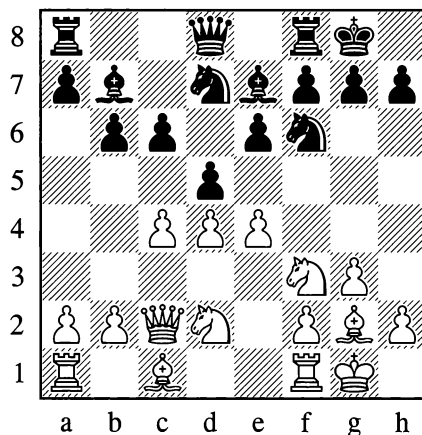
17... ♖f8 18. a5 ♖g6**19. ♗e3!N**

Improving over 19. ♗g5 as played in Yevseev – Lovkov, St Petersburg 2006, after which 19... ♗d8!N would have been unclear.

The text move sees White refrain from the bishop trade, leaving Black in a passive position without much counterplay.

19... ♗d7 20. ♖d2

White is significantly better.

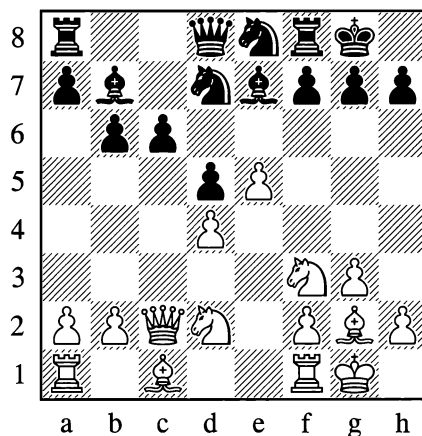
B22) 9... ♗b7**10. e5**

I believe White has to play this in order to fight for the advantage.

10. b3 ♗c8 11. ♗b2 c5 12. exd5 exd5 can be compared with the later variation B23, but the position of the bishop on b7 instead of a6 clearly helps Black.

10... ♖e8 11. cxd5

Now B221) 11... exd5 should be considered, but the main line is B222) 11... cxd5.

B221) 11... exd5

The arising pawn structure gives Black the clear plan of transferring his knight to e6, followed by attacking the centre with ...c5. Nevertheless, White should be able to obtain the better chances by regrouping his pieces behind the strong d4-e5 pawn wedge.

12.♞e1 ♘c7 13.♘f1

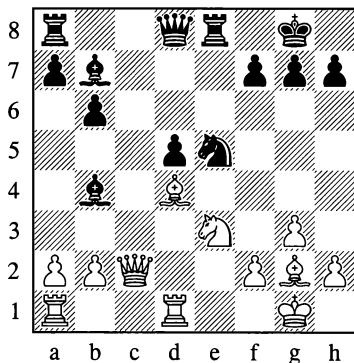
The knight is heading for e3 and hopefully f5 later.

13...♘e6

13...c5 14.♘e3 should lead to the same thing, as the knight will surely go to e6 in the near future.

14.♘e3 c5

14...♞e8 gives White time to improve his bishop with 15.♙d2 c5 16.♙c3. An important game continued: 16...cxd4 17.♘xd4 ♘xd4 18.♙xd4 ♙b4 19.♞ed1 ♘xe5



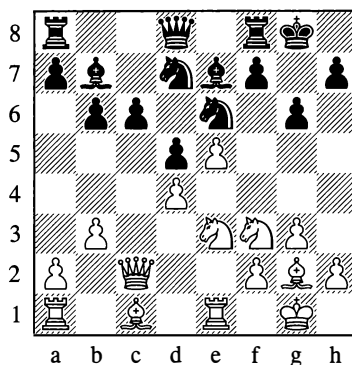
20.♞b3! ♘c6 21.♙xd5 ♞d7 22.♙c3 ♙xc3 23.♞xc3 ♞ad8 24.♞ac1 Despite the simplifications, Black was under heavy pressure in Bruzon Batista – Cuartas, Barcelona 2010.

14...g6

This prevents White's knight from coming to f5, but weakens the dark squares around Black's king.

15.b3

15.♘g4 is premature due to 15...h5, as in Schreiner – Lautner, Aschach 2011.



15...♞c8

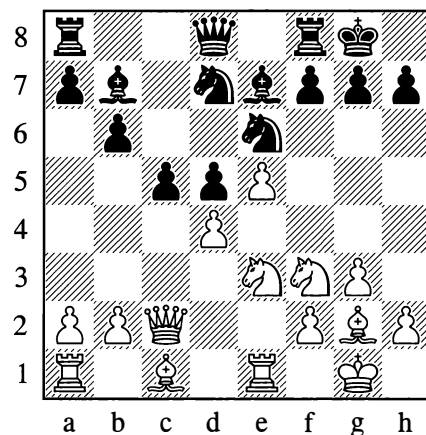
The more active 15...c5 was met by 16.♙b2 ♞c8 17.♞e2 and White got a nice edge, which significantly increased after 17...cxd4 18.♘xd4 ♘dc5 19.♞ad1 ♙a6 20.♞g4 in Meier – Schloetzer, Dresden 2010.

16.♙b2 ♞e8 17.♞d2 a5 18.♞ed1

I prefer this modest move to 18.a3, which was played in Khetsuriani – Pelletier, Athens 2005. A possible continuation is:

18...f5 19.exf6 ♘xf6 20.♘e5 ♙d6 21.♞ac1±

White maintains a pleasant edge.



15.♘f5 ♞e8

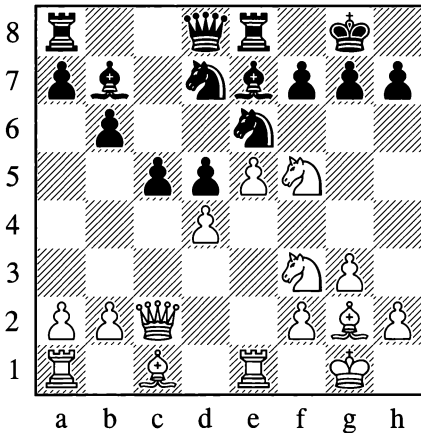
This seems like Black's best idea.

15...cxd4?! removes the tension prematurely, and after 16.♘3xd4 ♘xd4 17.♘xd4 ♘c5 18.♙e3 White has excellent prospects. 18...♞c8 19.♙h3 ♞c7 occurred in Diermair – Kubinger,

Aschach 2010, and now the simple 20.♖ac1N a5 21.♗d1 would have stabilized White's positional advantage.

15...♖c8 16.♗d1 ♖e8 has been played in a couple of games, and both times White exchanged on e7. Instead I would prefer 17.♕e3N ♕f8 18.♕h3!, when White keeps the better chances in a complex position.

The present position first occurred in Montalvo – De Toledo, Mermaid Beach 1997, and has been repeated in a few subsequent games. I propose a simple improvement:



16.b3!N

Other moves were less convincing to say the least.

16...♕f8

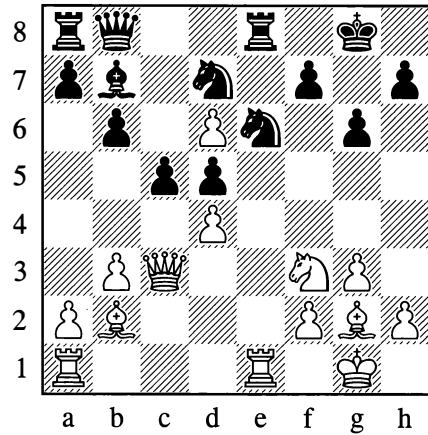
After 16...cxd4 17.♘xe7† ♗xe7 18.♕b2 ♖ac8 19.♗d2 White will regain his pawn and exert lasting pressure against the isolani.

17.♕b2 g6 18.♘d6!

An interesting pawn sacrifice.

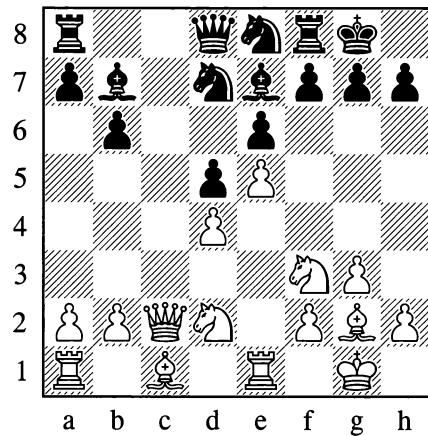
18...♕xd6 19.exd6 ♗b8 20.♗c3

20.♖ad1 ♗xd6 21.♗d2 also looks pretty good.



20...f6 21.h4 ♗xd6 22.h5 ♖ac8 23.♗d2
White has promising play for the pawn.

B222) 11...cxd5 12.♖e1



White's last move is almost an automatic choice when this 'French' pawn centre occurs. Depending on circumstances, White may activate his light-squared bishop with ♕f1-d3, or improve his misplaced knight with ♘d2-f1-e3-g4, perhaps developing the dark-squared bishop to f4 or g5 along the way. White's general aim is to activate his pieces in a way that will enable him to generate kingside attacking chances, while at the same time keeping Black's queenside activity in check, as well as preventing a queen exchange, which would significantly ease Black's defensive task.

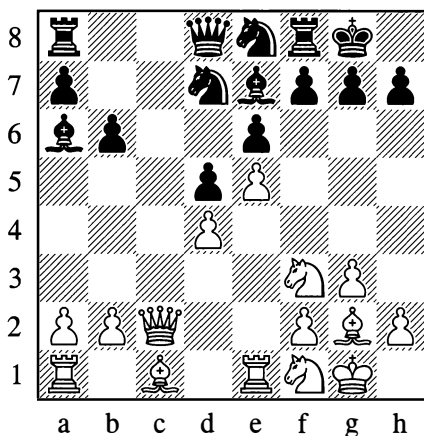
I have identified three main continuations in **B2221) 12...♙a6**, **B2222) 12...♖c7** and **B2223) 12...♞c8**, although I should make it clear that the last option has been the most popular by far.

12...♘c7 13.♘f1 ♞c8 14.♘e3 a5 15.h4 ♞e8 16.a3± gave White a comfortable edge in Tukmakov – Lalic, Tucepi 1996.

12...b5 13.♘f1 b4 does not make much sense to me, and White can easily develop his initiative: 14.h4 ♖c7 15.♖d3 ♞c8 16.♙g5! ♙xg5 17.♘g5 ♖c2 18.♖b5± White won a pawn in Baumegeger – Velcheva, Budapest 1997.

B2221) 12...♙a6 13.♘f1

It is also worth considering: 13.♙f1!? ♘c7 (13...♙xf1 14.♘xf1 ♖c7 15.♖a4 a6 occurred in Avrukh – Trajkovic, Internet 2004, and now 16.♙d2N b5 17.♖b3 would have been the most accurate, when White's advantage is beyond any doubt.) 14.a3!N (In *GM 1* I only mentioned 14.♙d3 ♙xd3 15.♖xd3 ♖c8, followed by ...♖a6, when Black is fine.) White can continue making useful waiting moves, and it is not clear how Black should organize his pieces. If 14...♞c8 15.♙d3! White just continues with his regrouping, while Black's counterplay is under a cloud now that the ...♖c8-a6 manoeuvre has been prevented.



13...♞c8 14.♖d1

Black's main problem is the passivity of his minor pieces, especially his knights, so it is logical to try and improve their positions.

14...♘b8

Here is another example where White instructively seized the initiative on the kingside: 14...♘c7 15.h4 h6 This move prevents the bishop from going to g5, but also creates a target for possible sacrifices. 16.h5 ♘b8 17.♘e3 ♘c6 18.♘g4 ♞e8 19.♙xh6! gxf6 20.♞c1 With ♖d2 coming next, White had a dangerous attack in Filippov – Frolyanov, Sochi 2005.

15.h4 ♘c6

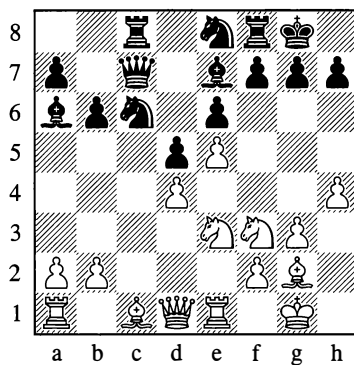
Another option is:

15...♖c7 16.♘e3

Certainly White should prevent Black's queen from coming to c2: 16.♘g5 ♖c2 17.♖g4 ♘c6 18.♘e3 ♖g6! White cannot avoid the queen swap (after ...h6), as 19.♖d1 is answered by 19...♖d3!.

16...♘c6

And now instead of creating additional targets for Black on the queenside with 17.a3, as in Mandekic – Tratar, Zadar 2004, I would recommend:



17.♙d2N ♙d3

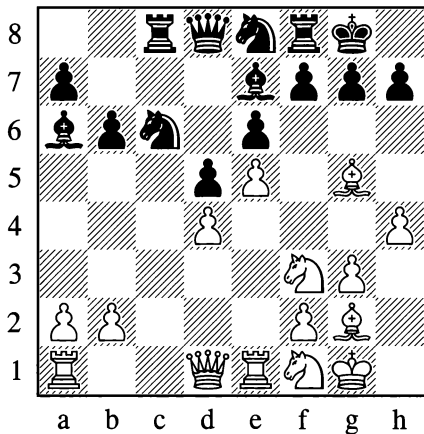
17...♘b4?? loses material after 18.♖a4.

18.♙c3 ♙e4 19.♙f1

White will follow up with ♞d2 , chasing the bishop from e4 and gaining plenty of space to develop a kingside initiative.

16. ♙g5

This is quite a tricky move.



16... ♙xg5

White does not need to worry about $16...\text{♞b4}?! 17.\text{♞e3} \text{h6}$ in view of $18.\text{a3}! \text{♞c6}$ ($18...\text{♞d3}?$ runs into $19.\text{♙xe7} \text{♞xe7} 20.\text{♞e2}+$ and Black's knight is trapped) $19.\text{♙f4}$ when Black has achieved nothing, while White's attack plays itself.

The natural $16...\text{h6}$ gives White a pleasant choice: $17.\text{♙d2}!?$ (The simple $17.\text{♙xe7} \text{♞xe7} 18.\text{♞c1}±$ also gives White an edge thanks to his space advantage.) Retreating the bishop to d2 is an ambitious choice, aiming for a future sacrifice on h6. It should be noted that $17...\text{♞b4}?!?$ is no good, as $18.\text{♞a4}! \text{♙xf1} 19.\text{♞xf1}±$ leaves White with a clear positional advantage.

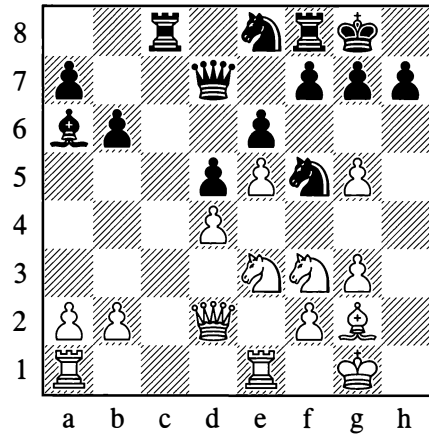
17. hxxg5

Now White can look to prepare a future knight sacrifice on f6.

17... ♞e7 18. ♞e3 ♞d7 19. ♞d2 ♞f5

At this point a draw was agreed in Filippov

– Khenkin, Fuegen 2006, but White has every reason to play on.



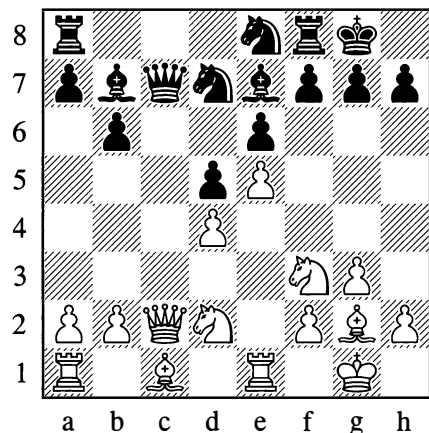
20. ♙f1!

In *GM 1* I gave $20.\text{♞xf5} \text{Nxf5} 21.\text{♞b4}!$, with ideas of a positional sacrifice with e5-e6. However, I later realized that the text move was a much simpler route to a clear advantage.

20... ♙xf1 21. ♙xf1 ♞a4 22. ♙g2 ♞xe3† 23. ♞xe3 ♞c2 24. ♞e2±

White has the simple plan of attacking along the h-file, and it is hard to suggest a good answer for Black.

B2222) 12... ♞c7



This also looks pretty logical.

13. ♖b3

13. ♖d3 will probably transpose after a couple more moves. There is also 13. ♖a4 ♖c6 14. ♖b3, which should reach the same position with an extra move played.

13... ♖c8

After 13...a5 14. ♘f1 even a high-level grandmaster and theoretician failed to create any serious counterplay for Black: 14... ♖c8 15. ♘e3 ♙a6 16. ♙d2 ♖c6 17. ♖ac1 ♖b7 18. ♖xc8 ♖xc8 19. ♖c1 ♘c7 20. h4 ♖d8 21. ♖c2! ♘a8 22. ♘g5 ♙xg5 23. hxg5 White had an overwhelming advantage in Swinkels – Tiviakov, Haaksbergen 2009.

14. ♙f1 ♘b8

The older move is:

14... ♖c2 15. ♖e3!

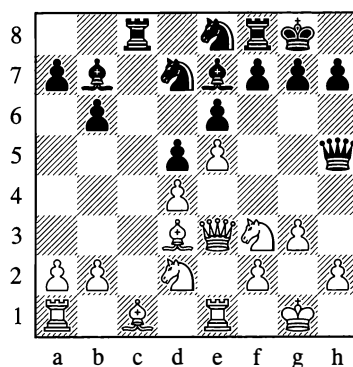
It is essential for White to avoid the queen trade. In the event of 15. ♖xc2N ♖xc2 16. ♙d3 ♖c8 he is only marginally better, and Black should hold without any serious difficulties.

15... ♖g6

This seems stronger than 15... ♘c7 16. ♙d3 ♖a4, when Black's queen is misplaced. 17. b3 ♖a5 This position occurred in Zakharevich – Geller, Tula 2001, and here I like 18. ♙b2. In *Chess Informant* 81, Zakharevich gives 18... ♙a3 (18... ♘b5 19. a3), but White has a strong riposte: 19. b4! ♙xb4 (19... ♖xb4?? loses to 20. ♙xa3 ♖xa3 21. ♙xh7+ followed by 22. ♖xa3) 20. a4! Threatening to trap the queen with ♘b3. 20... b5 21. axb5 ♖b6 22. ♖e2!± The strong b5-pawn seriously limits Black's activity on the queenside.

16. ♙d3 ♖b5

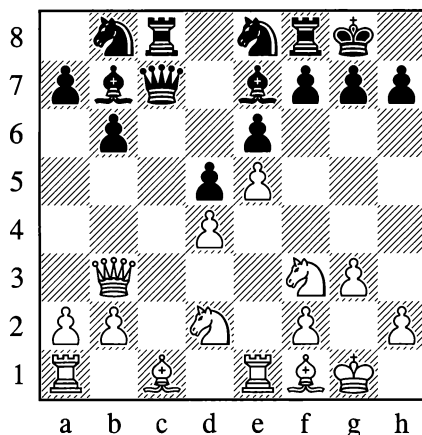
This position occurred in Larrass – Flemm, corr. 1988. A good continuation for White is:



17. ♘b3N ♘c7 18. ♙d2 ♙a6 19. ♖ac1 19... ♙c2 f6! gives Black counterplay. 19... ♙xd3 20. ♖xd3 ♖g6 21. ♖e2±

White is better, as Black's pieces lack coordination.

The text move was first played in Alburt – Westerinen, Reykjavik 1982, and it has recently emerged as Black's latest attempt to rehabilitate this line. His practical results have been decent, but so far nobody has found the best continuation for White.

**15. ♘b1!N**

A great regrouping move, which slows down Black's counterplay significantly.

15... ♘c6

A key point is that 15... ♖c2? is impossible in view of 16. ♖xc2 ♖xc2 17. ♘c3 ♙b4 18. ♖e3

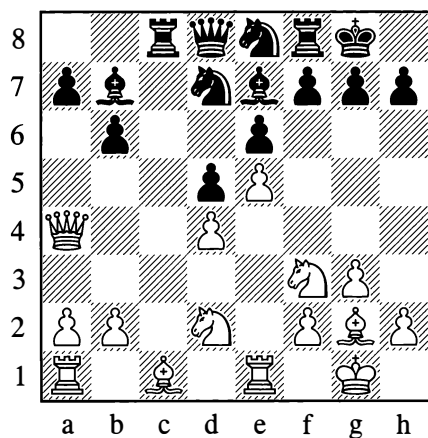
when the black rook is trapped behind enemy lines.

16. ♖c3 ♜a5 17. ♖d1 ♜c4 18. ♔d3

White has succeeded in keeping the queen-side under control, and it will not be at all easy for Black to do the same on the other flank.

B2223) 12... ♖c8 13. ♖a4

13. ♖d3 is less accurate due to 13... ♜b8! (13... ♖c7 14. ♔f1 ♖c2 15. ♖e3! transposes to the note to Black's 14th move in the previous variation) 14. ♜f1 ♔a6 15. ♖d1 ♜c6 16. ♜e3 ♜b4 17. ♔f1 ♔xf1 18. ♖xf1 f6∞ with counterplay for Black, Villamayor – Sandipan, Calcutta 2001.



13... ♔c6

Black has tried several moves, but White has achieved good results against all of them, and it is hard to call any of them the definitive main line. For the sake of simplicity, I have kept the same main line as in *GM 1*.

13... ♖c7 14. ♔f1 gives White easy play, and not much has changed since *GM 1*. 14... a6 15. ♔d3 ♜b8 16. h4 a5 17. a3 ♔a6 18. ♔b1 f6 A logical reaction, as Black clearly lacks space, but now the e6-pawn becomes a permanent weakness. 19. exf6 ♔xf6 20. ♜f1 ♖f7 21. ♔f4

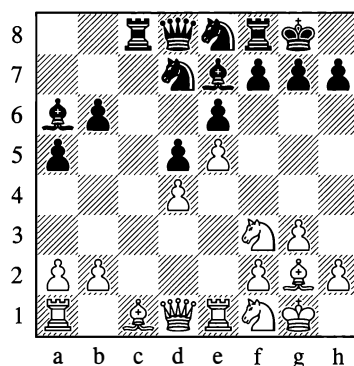
White was comfortably better in Stefanova – Molchanova, Sochi 2005.

13... a5 14. ♜f1!

14. ♔f1 ♜c7! transposes to 13... ♜c7 14. ♔f1 a5, which I now prefer to avoid, for reasons explained under the 13... ♜c7 line below.

14... ♔a6 15. ♖d1!

In *GM 1* I referenced a game after 15. h4 ♔d3 where White kept an edge, but preventing the bishop move is more ambitious.



15... ♜b8

15... b5 was once played against the young Carlsen, but the future world champion convincingly prevailed after 16. h4 b4 17. ♜g5 ♖c7 18. ♜e3 ♔xg5 19. hxg5 ♖b6 20. ♔f1! ♔xf1 21. ♜xf1 f5? 22. exf6 gxf6 23. ♜g4 in Carlsen – Leer Salvesen, Oslo 2006.

16. h4 ♜c6 17. a3 ♔b5 18. b3!?

Not the only good move, but it certainly limits Black's counterplay. In the following game Black tried a rather desperate pawn sacrifice, which soon backfired.

18... a4?! 19. bxa4 ♔c4 20. ♜e3 ♜a5 21. ♜xc4 dxc4 22. ♖b1!

White was clearly better in Mchedlishvili – Karakehajov, Konya 2010.

13... ♜c7

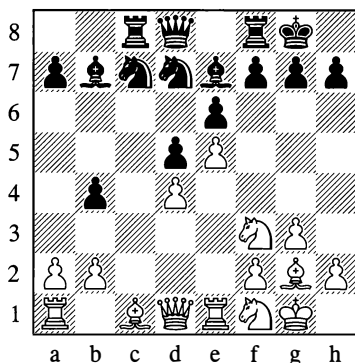
This seems like quite a logical try, improving the passive knight and preparing ... ♔a6.

14.♘f1!

In *GM 1* I gave 14.♙f1 a5 15.♙d3 ♙a6 16.♙b1 as my main line. It looks tempting to involve the light-squared bishop in the kingside offensive, but it turns out that Black can exploit White's temporary lack of coordination to create counterplay. 16...f5! (Improving over 16...♘b5 17.♙b3 as seen in Avrukh – Filippov, Halkidiki 2002.) 17.exf6 ♜xf6 With double-edged play, Halldorsson – Kuzubov, Reykjavik 2010.

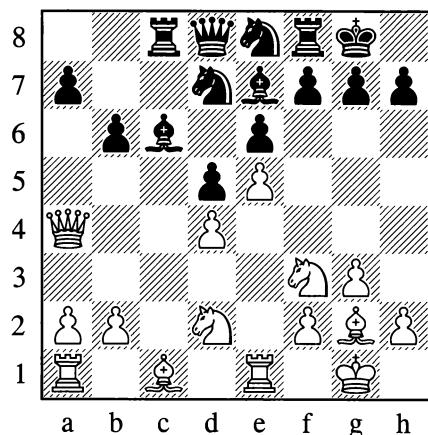
14...b5 15.♙d1 b4

This has been Black's most popular plan in this line, but White has achieved a huge practical score. I will just mention one practical example.



16.h4 ♘b8 17.♙g5 ♘c6 18.♘e3 f6 19.exf6 gxf6 20.♙h6±

Black was in trouble in Izoria – Agrest, Las Vegas 2003.



14.♙b3

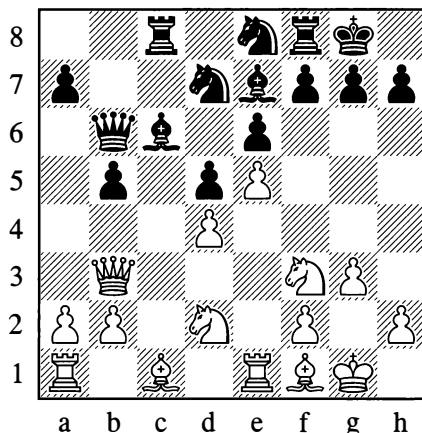
I prefer not to allow 14.♙d1 ♙b5, even though 15.♙f1 ♙xf1 16.♘xf1 still gives White the better chances thanks to his space advantage.

14...b5

Obviously Black should try to get some activity on the queenside.

15.♙f1 ♙b6

After 15...b4 I won a smooth game: 16.♙a6! This strong intermediate move disturbs Black's coordination. 16...♙b8 17.♙d3 ♙b5 18.♙b1 ♜c8 19.♘f1 ♘b6 20.h4 ♙c7 21.♙g5 ♙xg5? (21...♘c4N is a better try, although 22.♘1h2 keeps a clear advantage for White) 22.♘xg5 h6 23.♘h7+– Avrukh – Al Tamimi, Bajada de la Virgen 2005.

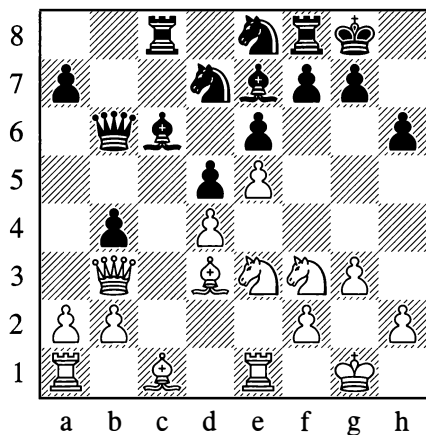


16.♙d3 b4 17.♘f1 h6

Covering the g5-square. In a more recent game Black neglected to do so, and after 17...♙b5 18.♙g5! ♙d8 White suddenly switched to a positional approach: 19.♙xd8! ♜xd8 20.♙xb5 ♙xb5 21.♜ac1 Black had no easy life with his knight stuck on e8 in Hillarp Persson – Carstensen, Copenhagen 2010.

18.♘e3!N

Improving on 18.♔f4 ♕b5 19.♕b1 f5 20.exf6 ♖exf6∞ when Black obtained decent counterplay in Izoria – Nadera, Dubai 2004.



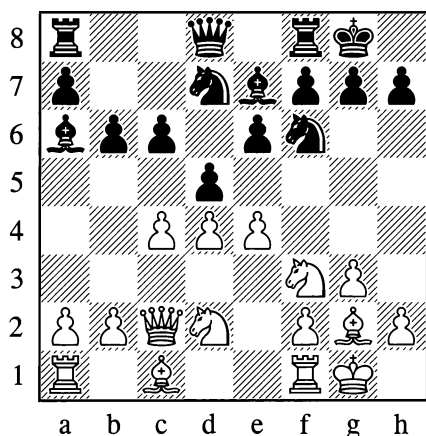
18...♖c7 19.♕b1

Black was threatening ...♖b5.

19...♞fd8 20.♕d2 a5 21.♖g2!±

White's chances are preferable, as he has good prospects of developing an initiative on the kingside by means of ♖e3-f4-g4, and/or ♖f4-h5.

B23) 9...♕a6

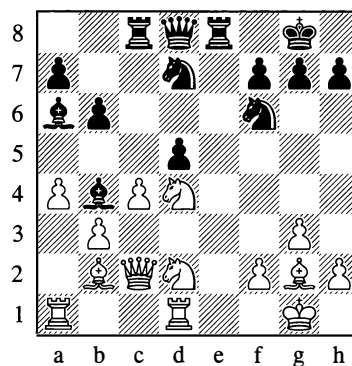


This leads to a different type of game from the previous bishop move. If White blocked

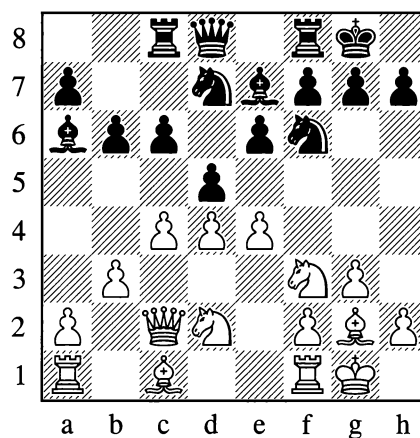
the centre with e4-e5 then the bishop would be more active on a6, but if we maintain the central tension then the opposite is true.

10.b3 ♞c8

10...c5 11.exd5 exd5 12.♕b2 almost always transposes after 12...♞c8. The only noteworthy independent path is 12...cxd4 13.♖xd4 ♞c8, when 14.a4!N transposes to a game that turned out nicely for White: 14...♕b4 (14...dxc4 15.♖xc4 ♖e5 16.♖b5! also favours White) 15.♞fd1 ♞e8



16.♖f1! ♞e7 17.♖e3 dxc4 18.♖c6 ♞f8 19.♖xc4± The c6-knight had become a monster in Kirov – Boehm, Lyon 1995.



11.♕b2 c5

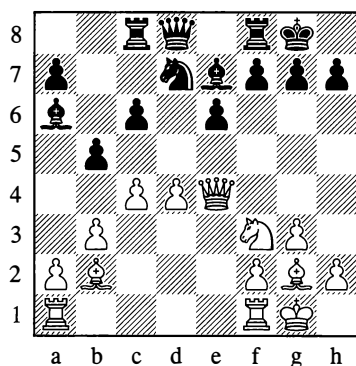
The modest 11...♞c7 has been played, but I don't understand it, as the simple 12.e5! ♖e8

13.♞f1 left the knight clearly misplaced on e8 in Kostiukova – Mironenko, Evpatoria 2007.

11...dxe4 12.♘xe4 ♘xe4 13.♞xe4 b5

13...c5 14.♞ad1 clearly favours White, as Black's bishop is misplaced on a6 and Black will hardly want to capture on d4, as White's knight would be heading straight to c6.

The present position has been considered worse for Black ever since following game from 1979, which remains as instructive as ever.

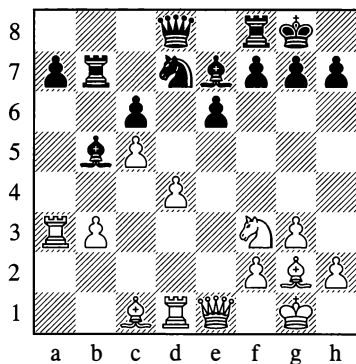


14.c5 b4 15.♞fd1 ♙b5

Black has managed to activate his light-squared bishop but, in doing so, he has created other weaknesses in his camp, which White expertly exploits.

16.♞e1! ♞b8 17.a3 bxa3 18.♞xa3 ♞b7 19.♙c1!

Another strong move; the bishop will be more active on the c1-h6 diagonal.

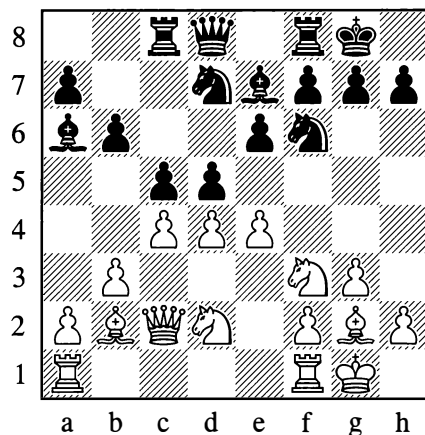


19...♘f6 20.♙g5 ♘d5

In the event of 20...h6 21.♙d2 ♘d5 22.♘e5 Black cannot chase the knight away with ...f6, as it would decisively weaken the g6-square.

21.♙xe7 ♘xe7 22.♘e5±

White had an obvious positional advantage thanks to Black's weak queenside pawns in Quinteros – Petrosian, Buenos Aires 1979.



12.exd5 exd5 13.♞fd1!

This is a major departure from my previous recommendation of 13.♞f5 g6 14.♞h3, when 14...b5! is a recent invention that seems to solve Black's opening problems. For instance: 15.cxb5 I checked some other moves, but was unable to find anything convincing for White. 15...♙xb5 16.♞fc1 ♙d3!? 17.dxc5 h5 18.♘d4? Black eventually lost due to subsequent mistakes in Jaworski – Rojicek, Czech Republic 2011, but at this point 18...♘xc5N would have left him with a clear advantage.

Apart from posting the rook on an active square, White's last move also has the advantage of preparing the ♘f1-e3 manoeuvre. Black's two most important continuations are B231) 13...♞e8 and B232) 13...cxd4. I would also like to mention a couple of minor options:

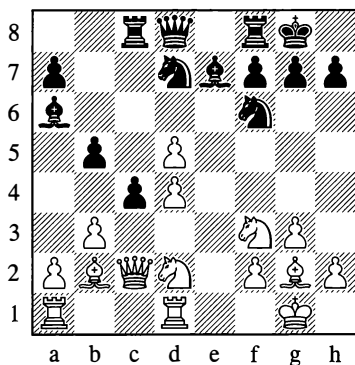
13...b5 14.cxd5

I also considered the remarkable 14.b4!?, although after 14...cxb4 15.c5 ♖b7 16.♗d3 ♕c6 (16...a6 17.♕h3) 17.a3 bxa3 18.♗xa3 ♖e4! Black was doing okay in Kalinitschew – Dgebuadze, Meisdorf 1996. This could be investigated in more detail, but the main continuation seems more straightforward.

14...c4

In the event of 14...♖xd5N 15.dxc5 ♖xc5 16.♖f1 ♕b7 17.♗e2 ♗e8 18.♖e5 ♖b6 19.♕xb7 ♖xb7 20.♖e3 White has a serious initiative thanks to his much more active pieces.

This position occurred in Grigorian – Ilinsky, Moscow 1983, and seven subsequent games.



15.♖e5!N

Surprisingly, 15.bxc4 has been the unanimous choice so far.

15...c3 16.♕xc3

This is my preference, although 16.♖c6 is also worth considering. I analysed 16...cxb2 17.♗xb2 ♗xc6 18.dxc6 ♖b6 19.♖e4! and White's position looks promising.

16...♖xd5 17.♕xd5 ♖xe5 18.♗e4 ♖d3 19.♕a5! ♗xa5 20.♗xd3

Black does not have enough compensation for the missing pawn.

13...♕b7

This was played in Polovodin – Lputian, Irkutsk 1983, and several subsequent games.

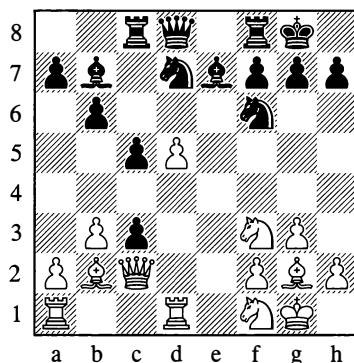
(The position has also occurred with Black to move quite a few times.)

14.♖f1!N

This typical knight manoeuvre looks best, especially taking into account that 14.♗f5 dxc4 15.♖xc4 b5∞ has proven pretty reliable for Black.

14...dxc4 15.d5! c3

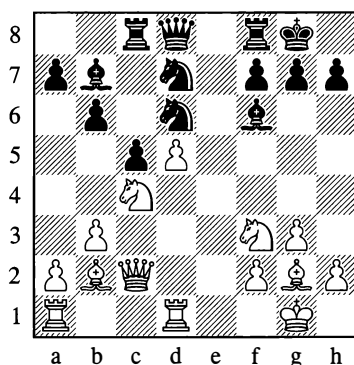
The pawn is poisoned: 15...♕xd5? 16.♖g5 ♕xg2 17.♕xf6 wins material, while 15...♖xd5? 16.bxc4 ♖b4 17.♗f5 ♗c7 18.♖e5± also leaves Black in trouble.



16.♗xc3 ♖e8 17.♖e3

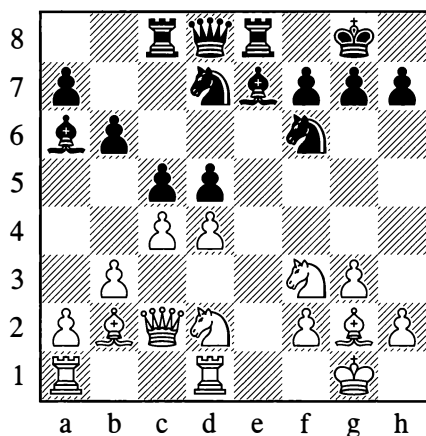
17.d6 seems tempting, but after 17...♕f6 18.♗c2 ♕xb2 19.♗xb2 ♗f6! I am not sure about the future of the d6-pawn after the queen exchange, even though the computer still prefers White.

17...♕f6 18.♗c2 ♖d6 19.♖c4



White is definitely better; the d5-pawn is well supported, and Black has no real counterplay.

B231) 13...♖e8

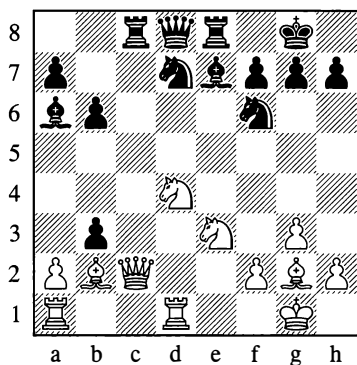


14.♘f1!

Surprisingly, this strong move has been tested only once. 14.♗f5 and 14.♖ac1 have been more popular.

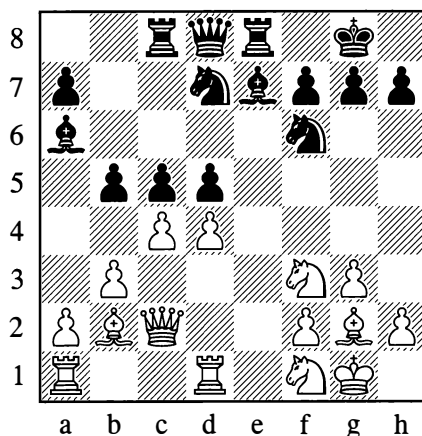
14...b5

14...cxd4N is obviously an important alternative. Play continues 15.♘xd4 dxc4 16.♘e3! with the following idea: 16...cxb3



17.♗b1! ♖c7 18.axb3 ♗c8 19.♗a2 ♙b7 20.♘b5 ♖c5 21.♘xa7 ♗b8 22.b4 ♖c7 23.♘b5 ♖cc8 24.♗b3 ♙xg2 25.♙xg2 White has a large positional advantage.

The text move was played in A. Mikhalevski – Zoler, Israel 2010. According to my analysis, White has only one way to fight for an advantage.



15.cxd5!N ♘xd5

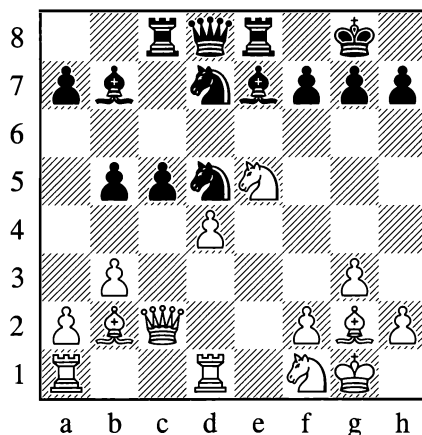
15...♙b7 16.♘e5 ♙xd5 (16...♘xd5 17.♗f5 transposes to the main line) 17.♙xd5 ♘xd5 18.♗d3! cxd4 19.♙xd4 ♙f8 20.♘g4! is better for White, who can meet both 20...b4 and 20...a6 with 21.♙xg7!.

16.♘e5

16.dxc5 ♖xc5 17.♗d3 ♙b7 does not seem like anything special for White.

16...♙b7

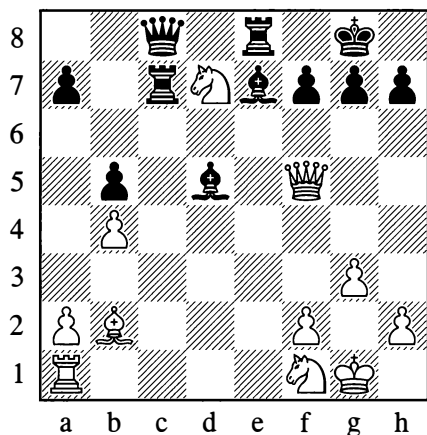
In the event of 16...cxd4 17.♘c6 ♘e5 18.♖xd4 ♖xc6 19.♗d1 Black is under unpleasant pressure.



17.♗f5 ♘7f6 18.dxc5

White retains the better chances, thanks to the following critical line:

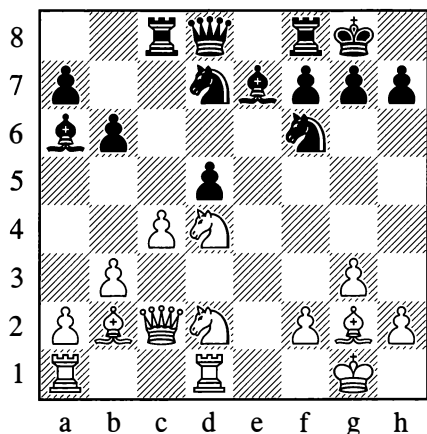
18...♖xc5 19.b4 ♗c8 20.♘d7! ♖c7 21.♙xd5 ♘xd5 22.♖xd5 ♙xd5



23.♗e5 f6 24.♗xd5† ♔h8 25.♘c5 ♙xc5 26.bxc5 ♖xc5 27.♗b3‡

White's two minor pieces are stronger than Black's rook and pawn.

B232) 13...cxd4 14.♘xd4



14...b5

This seems critical, and was the reason why I rejected 13.♖fd1 previously. However, I changed my mind after taking a fresh look at the ensuing complications.

The most popular alternative is 14...♖e8, but the following game offers a convincing argument for White: 15.♗f5 g6 16.♗g5! The queen does not have to retreat to h3, which it usually does after ♗f5 in these positions. 16...♙f8 17.♘f5 dxc4 18.bxc4 ♖c5 19.♘h6† ♙xh6 20.♗xh6 ♖h5 21.♗f4 ♗b8 22.♗xb8 ♖xb8 23.♘e4 White had a clear advantage in Lima – Pelikian, Santos 2001.

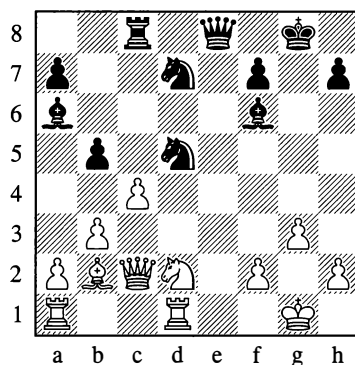
15.♘f5!

This rare move is stronger than the more popular 15.♗f5.

15...bxc4

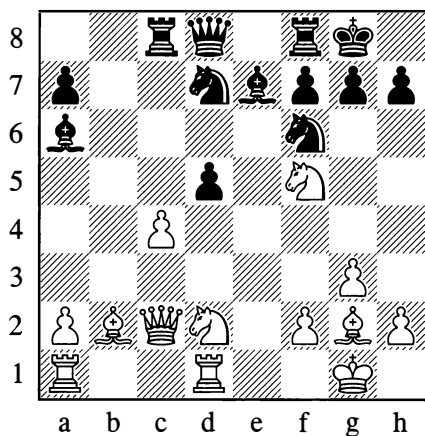
15...♙c5? was played in Eljanov – Azarov, Ohrid 2001. Apparently both players overlooked 16.♙xd5!N ♘xd5 17.♘e4! with a winning position for White.

15...♖e8 resembles our main line below. 16.♙xd5! ♘xd5 17.♘g7 ♙f6 18.♘xe8 ♗xe8 occurred in A. Mikhalevski – Kaganskiy, Israel 2011, and here White could have obtained some advantage with:



19.♖e1!N (19.♘e4!N ♙xb2 20.♘d6! ♗e5 21.♘xc8 ♙xa1 22.cxd5 also favours White, but the text move seems clearer) 19...♗d8 20.♘e4 bxc4 21.♖ad1! The following sequence is more or less forced. 21...♙xb2 22.♖xd5 ♙b7 23.♖dd1 ♙e5 24.♗e2 ♙xe4 25.♗xe4 ♙g7 26.♗f5 ♖c7 27.bxc4 White has good winning chances.

16.bxc4

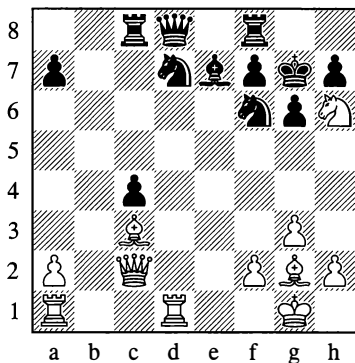


16...♞e8!N

This untested move seems like the only playable option for Black. Others are much worse:

16...♙c5?N 17.♘b3 ♙xc4 18.♘xc5 ♘xc5 19.♘xg7! ♘xg7 20.♞f5 h6 21.♞d4! White's attack is too powerful.

16...♙xc4? 17.♘xc4 dxc4 (17...♙xc4N 18.♞d3 also leads to serious problems for Black, who must worry about ideas such as ♙xd5, ♘xe7+ followed by ♙a3, and ♞e3 followed by ♞g5.) 18.♙c3 g6 19.♘h6+ ♘g7 occurred in Gregory – Gray, England 2012.



And now 20.♞c1!N would have left Black without a good defence against ♘g4.

17.♙xd5! ♘xd5 18.♘xg7

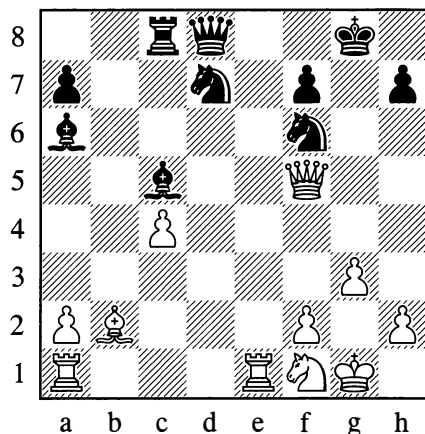
This piece sacrifice is an important attacking motif, which we also encountered after 15...♞e8 in the notes above. The position can be investigated more deeply, but I consider it promising for White, and will just show a few illustrative lines.

18...♙c5 19.♘f1 ♘5f6 20.♘xe8 ♞xe8 21.♞e1 ♞d8

21...♞f8? 22.♞ad1 is much worse for Black.

22.♞f5!

22.♘e3 ♞b6 23.♞ab1 ♞c6 24.♞f5 ♞e4 is not so clear. Now a logical sequence might be:



22...♞b6 23.♞ab1 ♙d4 24.♙xd4 ♞xd4 25.♞g5+ ♘h8 26.♘e3 ♞g8 27.♞f5

White has an ideal situation, with realistic winning chances and not much risk at all.

Conclusion

The Closed Catalan remains a popular choice for Black, making the present chapter one of the more important ones in the book. Starting with the sidelines after both 6...c6 and 6...♘bd7, we dealt with a variety of position types resembling different variations of the Queen's Indian, where White's chances seem preferable.

The main lines occur after 7...c6 8.♘bd2 b6 9.e4, when Black has three main moves. 9...dxe4 is the worst-scoring option for Black, who needs to play accurately just to avoid sinking into abject passivity. Even after his most resilient continuation, I found a suitable improvement over *GM 1* to maintain White's pleasant advantage.

9...♙b7 10.e5 ♘e8 is a popular continuation, when the usual 11.cxd5 cxd5 reaches a French-like structure. The overall verdict is the same as in *GM 1*, as White has enough resources to limit his opponent's counterplay while generating real attacking possibilities on the kingside. However, I was able to fine-tune the recommendations, with several refinements at key moments.

Finally we looked at 9...♙a6 10.b3 ♖c8 11.♙b2 c5 12.exd5 exd5, which leads to an extremely tense middlegame where multiple pawn captures might be available at any time. 13.♖fd1! is an important departure from my previous recommendation, when the ♘f1-e3 manoeuvre offers White excellent chances in many lines, although a good level of tactical awareness will be needed.